



THE 0-3 HUMILIATION HAS ALSO LEFT INDIA GASPING FOR AIR IN THE WORLD TEST CHAMPIONSHIP (WTC) STANDINGS

[Muttiah Muralitharan], [Shane] Warne, or Saqi [Saqlain Mushtaq] on these pitches to get teams out. Anyone can get anyone out."

Following criticism a few years ago, the team management shifted its reliance to pacers and began using sporting wickets that

Rewarding comeback: Returning to the Test side after three years, off-spinner Washington Sundar shone in Pune, taking seven wickets in the first innings and four in the second.

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extended Tests into the fourth day. But under Gambhir, the strategy leaned toward spin and rank turners, and the results spun out of India's control.

Questionable selection calls

Opting for rank turners wasn't the only mistake; India also made questionable selection calls, often playing a bowler short.

In the first Test, played on a Bengaluru surface that clearly called

for a third pacer, India instead picked Kuldeep Yadav. The left-arm wrist-spinner ended up as the most expensive of India's bowlers, while New Zealand's pacers thrived from the start.

In Pune, where New Zealand's spinners led by Mitchell Santner wreaked havoc, India fielded two pacers, Jasprit Bumrah and Akash Deep. Akash bowled only six overs in the first innings and remained unused in the second. A similar situation played out in Mumbai's Wankhede Stadium, where India replaced the rested Bumrah with Mohammed Siraj. Like Akash in Pune, Siraj spent most of the game as a bystander as Rohit chose not to utilise him in the second innings.

Silver linings

Despite the disappointing series, a few positives stood out, notably Washington Sundar's emergence.

Returning to the Test side after three years, the off-spinner shone in Pune, taking seven wickets in the first innings and four in the second.

Washington also contributed with the bat, providing India a hopeful glimpse of the future as it contemplates a post-Ashwin and Jadeja era. The 25-year-old had the highest batting average (44.5) among Indian players and the best bowling average (14.12) in the series. Pant's ongoing excellence and calmness under pressure also offered a bright spot in an otherwise challenging series.

While it's important to dissect India's shortcomings, New Zealand's achievement deserves praise. The Kiwis' success was even more remarkable given their recent struggles against Sri Lanka and their comparatively modest spin attack.

Poor field placements

Ashwin and Jadeja's struggle with the ball was exacerbated by captain Rohit's overly defensive field placements. Both spinners often bowled with a long-on or long-off, giving New Zealand's batters easy opportunities to rotate the strike and relieve pressure. India's bowlers allowed a single or double on 23.79% of deliveries, meaning New Zealand's batters rarely had to seek boundaries, allowing them to build runs steadily.

India also lacked close-in fielders, with Sarfaraz Khan as the sole regular presence at short leg.

Looking ahead

With only two home Tests scheduled in the next year — against the West Indies in October — it wouldn't be surprising if the current core of India's Test side, including Kohli, Rohit, Jadeja, and Ashwin, has played its last home game together in the longest format.

This transition has been on the horizon for some time, but New Zealand's dominance has highlighted the challenges India faces in ensuring a smooth change of guard and maintaining its formidable home record.